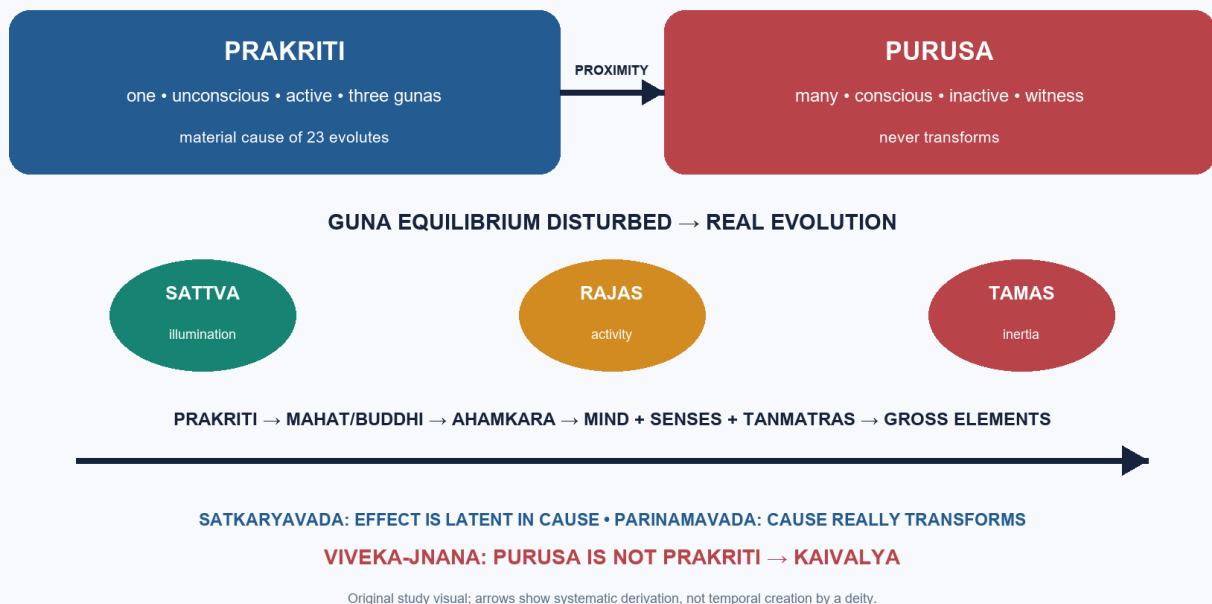


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

SAMKHYA - Syllabus Item 16 (Paper I - Section B)

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

SAMKHYA: ONE PRAKRITI, THREE GUNAS, MANY PURUSAS



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

SAMKHYA - Syllabus Item 16 (Paper I - Section B)

12. PYQ ROUTING (2018–2025)

ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal:** 10 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper I corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2018	Q5(e)	10 marks	Is Puruṣa one or many? Explain the Sāṃkhya position in this regard and give arguments in support of your answer.
2018	Q7(b)	15 marks	How do the Advaita Vedāntins react to the Prakṛtipariṇāma-vāda of the Sāṃkhya philosophy? How do the Sāṃkhyas defend their own position in this regard? Discuss.
2019	Q5(d)	10 marks	Critically discuss the metaphysical status of a Jīva and a Puruṣa according to Sāṃkhya philosophy.
2019	Q8(c)	15 marks	Which Sāṃkhya proof for the existence of Prakṛti actually shows that there can be only one Prakṛti? Justify your answer.
2020	Q7(a)	20 marks	“A mango tree is grown out of a mango seed.” How will Sāṃkhya system explain this process through their theory of causation by rejecting their rival perspectives?
2021	Q6(b)	15 marks	Explain the Sāṃkhya view on three guṇas (guṇa-traya) and their modifications.
2022	Q5(a)	10 marks	Examine and evaluate the proofs given by Sāṃkhya philosophy to prove the existence of Puruṣa.
2023	Q5(b)	10 marks	“If Puruṣa and Prakṛti are two completely independent realities, then no relation between the two is possible.” In the light of this statement make a brief presentation of Śaṅkara’s criticism of Sāṃkhya dualism.
2024	Q7(a)	20 marks (10+10)	Present an account of evolution of Prakṛti as propounded in Sāṃkhyakārikā. In this context, also explain the difference between buddhi, mahat and ahaṃkāra.
2025	Q7(a)	20 marks	Why does Śaṅkara consider Sāṃkhya Philosophy as his chief opponent (pradhāna malla)? Examine his arguments against Sāṃkhya Philosophy.

See the Indian Philosophy PYQ Bank, 2018–2025.

13. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

13.1 10-mark format

- ANALYSIS: Start with the technical thesis in one line.
- ANALYSIS: Give the numbered proof / sequence / distinction directly.
- ANALYSIS: Add one contrast or objection.
- ANALYSIS: End with a judgement tied to the directive word.

13.2 15-mark format

- ANALYSIS: Frame the doctrinal problem in 2-3 lines.
- ANALYSIS: Expose the doctrine in ordered points.
- ANALYSIS: Add distinction, comparison or criticism required by the question.
- ANALYSIS: End with one reasoned verdict.

13.3 20-mark format

- ANALYSIS: Frame Sāṃkhya as a full metaphysical system, not a school-summary.

- ANALYSIS: Body A: full doctrine in sequence.
- ANALYSIS: Body B: strongest rival or criticism.
- ANALYSIS: Body C: reply and evaluation.
- ANALYSIS: End with a philosophical conclusion, not a slogan.

13.4 Ready skeletons

Proofs for Puruṣa

Define Puruṣa as pure consciousness distinct from the guṇas.

List: saṅghāta-parārthatvāt, triguṇādi-viparyayāt, adhiṣṭhānāt, bhoktā-bhāvāt, kaivalyārthapravṛttau.

Evaluate their cumulative force.

Close: experience and liberation presuppose a witness-self.

Evolution of Prakṛti

Start with guṇa-equilibrium in avyakta Prakṛti.

Narrate: Prakṛti → mahat/buddhi → ahaṅkāra → sūttvika and tāmasa lines; rajas energizes both.

Clarify that mahat and buddhi are one tattva.

Close with the psychological-cosmological unity of the scheme.

Śaṅkara as critic

State Sāṃkhya dualism briefly.

Raise the contact problem.

Show why unconscious pradhāna cannot be the Upaniṣadic cause.

Conclude why Sāṃkhya is the chief but rejected rival.

14. LINK-OUTS

- Yoga — shared metaphysics + Īśvara addition
- Vedānta — pariṇāma vs vivarta; Śaṅkara's critique
- Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika — asatkāryavāda contrast
- Causation across schools
- Self and liberation
- Pramāṇa across schools
- Notions of God
- PYQ Bank
- Master Framework

SOURCES

- Īśvarakṛṣṇa, *Sāṃkhya-kārikā*.
- S. Chatterjee & D. Datta, *An Introduction to Indian Philosophy*.
- C.D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*.
- S. Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy* vol. 2.
- Vācaspati Miśra, *Sāṃkhya-tattva-kaumudī*.

CURRENT LINKAGE STATUS

FACT: Search result, 16 August 2026: No reliable official development specifically applying or revising Samkhya doctrine was verified for February-August 2026. A web result claiming adoption of a national "Samkhya Paradigm" in mental-health policy was not supported by an official government source and is excluded. Broad Indian Knowledge Systems activity is context only, not doctrinal evidence.

Direct local source anchors

- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta, local OCR edition, especially file pages 205-216: satkaryavada, Prakriti, gunas, Purusa and evolution.

- FACT: C. D. Sharma, local OCR edition, especially file pages 149-159: causation, one Prakriti, three gunas, Purusa, contact problem and evolutes.
- FACT: The repository PYQ bank controls wording, marks and ownership for all ten solved questions.

PART II - SOLVED PYQs, PRACTICE AND ANSWER TRAINING

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q5(e), 10 marks

Question: Is Purusa one or many? Explain the Samkhya position and arguments.

Model solution

Samkhya accepts **many Purusas**. Each Purusa is eternal, inactive, attributeless pure consciousness, but numerical plurality is required to explain differences among embodied streams.

The standard arguments are:

1. **Separate births and deaths:** one organism begins or ends without all doing so.
2. **Non-simultaneous activity:** when one sleeps, another acts.
3. **Diversity of experience:** pleasure, pain and knowledge differ among persons.
4. **Moral individuality:** karmic fruits attach to distinct empirical streams.
5. **Non-simultaneous liberation:** one person's release does not liberate all.

Advaita objects that attributeless consciousness cannot be numerically differentiated; apparent plurality may arise from distinct adjuncts. Samkhya replies that if only one Purusa existed, bondage and liberation would become universally simultaneous.

Verdict: Plurality protects moral and soteriological individuality, though the principle distinguishing qualitatively identical Purusas remains under-explained.

Why this earns marks: It states the position, gives five arguments, adds the Advaita objection and reaches a qualified conclusion.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: How do Advaita Vedantins react to Prakritiparinamavada, and how does Samkhya defend itself?

Model solution

Samkhya holds that Prakriti really transforms into the world. The effect pre-exists in the cause and becomes manifest through **parinama**. Advaita accepts satkaryavada at a broad level but rejects independent unconscious Prakriti and real transformation of ultimate reality.

Sankara's objections are:

1. An unconscious pradhana cannot initiate purposive, ordered evolution.
2. If Purusa is inactive and Prakriti independent, their relation is unintelligible.
3. The Upanisads present an intelligent principle, not unconscious matter, as world-ground.
4. Real transformation would compromise the changelessness of ultimate reality.
5. Two independent absolutes leave their coordination unexplained.

Advaita therefore proposes **vivartavada**: the world is an appearance of Brahman through maya, not a real transformation of Brahman.

Samkhya replies that effects share the guna-structure of their cause and require material continuity. Milk changes into curd without an external intelligent planner; similarly Prakriti's inherent tendency and Purusa's proximity suffice. A God does not explain how consciousness creates unconscious matter, whereas Prakriti naturally contains the material potency of the world.

Verdict: Samkhya explains real causal continuity better; Advaita presses the deeper problem of how unconscious teleology and dual coordination are possible.

Why this earns marks: It presents both schools symmetrically, distinguishes parinama from vivarta, and evaluates the material-continuity versus intelligence dispute.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q5(d), 10 marks

Question: Critically discuss the metaphysical status of Jiva and Purusa.

Model solution

Purusa is pure, eternal, inactive consciousness—witness, not agent or product. **Jiva** is Purusa apparently associated with the subtle body, buddhi, ahamkara, manas, senses and karmic dispositions.

Purusa	Jiva
pure consciousness	empirical embodied subject
inactive witness	appears as knower, doer, enjoyer
unbound in itself	subject to bondage and transmigration
plural and eternal	psychophysical stream around one Purusa

Buddhi is material but sattva-predominant and reflects consciousness. Ahamkara appropriates this reflected awareness as "I know" and "I act." Bondage belongs strictly to Prakriti's apparatus, yet is attributed to Purusa through non-discrimination.

The criticism is severe: if Purusa is never really bound, liberation appears unnecessary; if Jiva alone is bound, it is unclear who seeks release. Samkhya replies that liberation removes false identification, not a real modification of Purusa.

Why this earns marks: It gives the precise distinction, explains reflection and false appropriation, and identifies the paradox of an eternally free Purusa.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2019 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question: Which proof for Prakriti establishes that there can be only one Prakriti?

Model solution

The decisive proof is **avibhagat vaisvarupyasya**: the differentiated universe points to an undivided source. The cosmos displays immense plurality but also systemic unity and reciprocal transformation. Its differentiated forms must emerge from one unmanifest matrix in which they are not yet divided.

The other proofs establish the need for a material ground:

- *bhedanam parimanat*: finite effects require a ground.
- *samanvayat*: common guna-structure suggests a common cause.
- *karyatah pravrtteh*: productive activity presupposes potency.
- *karana-karya-vibhagat*: manifest effect differs from unmanifest causal state.

These support Prakriti's existence, but they do not as directly exclude multiple root causes. The fifth proof specifically moves from unified diversification to one undivided source.

An opponent may argue that cosmic coordination does not logically prove numerical unity; several coordinated causes are possible. Samkhya replies that multiple Prakritis with the same guna-constitution are explanatorily redundant and would require a higher principle coordinating them.

Verdict: The proof is abductive rather than demonstrative: one Prakriti is the most economical common material explanation of an interconnected guna-world.

Why this earns marks: It identifies the exact proof, distinguishes it from the other four and justifies both its force and limitation.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2020 Q7(a), 20 marks

Question: A mango tree grows from a mango seed. Explain through Samkhya causation while rejecting rivals.

Model solution

Samkhya explains the mango tree through **satkaryavada**: the effect exists latently in its material cause before manifestation. The seed is not an actual miniature tree, but it contains the determinate material potency that can unfold into that tree under suitable conditions.

Five arguments support the doctrine:

1. **Asadakaranat**: what is absolutely non-existent cannot be produced.
2. **Upadana-grahanat**: production requires a specific material cause.
3. **Sarvasambhavabhavat**: everything cannot arise from everything.
4. **Saktasya sakya-karanat**: a cause produces only what lies within its capacity.
5. **Karana-bhavat**: effect retains the nature of the cause.

The seed-to-tree process is **parinamavada**, real transformation. Production is manifestation; destruction is return to an unmanifest condition. Soil, water and heat are auxiliaries, while the seed carries mango-specific causal power.

Nyaya's asatkaryavada says the tree is newly produced and had prior absence. Samkhya objects that if wholly absent, its production from this rather than any cause is unintelligible. Nyaya replies that capacity, not latent effect, limits production.

Buddhist dependent origination treats seed and tree as momentary causal series without enduring material identity. Samkhya argues that a shared substrate and continuity better explain determinate transformation.

Advaita vivartavada treats worldly transformation as appearance relative to Brahman. Samkhya insists the empirical world and its changes are real and require real material evolution.

Verdict: Satkaryavada powerfully explains specificity and continuity, though critics may say it redescribes capacity as pre-existence and weakens genuine novelty.

Why this earns marks: It applies all five arguments to the example, distinguishes real transformation, and answers Nyaya, Buddhist and Advaita rivals.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 Q6(b), 15 marks

Question: Explain the three gunas and their modifications.

Model solution

Prakriti consists of **sattva, rajas and tamas**, not as qualities added to a substance but as its constitutive strands.

Guna	Character	Psychological expression	Physical tendency
Sattva	illumination, lightness	clarity, pleasure, knowledge	upward/light
Rajas	activity, stimulation	desire, effort, restlessness	motion
Tamas	restraint, heaviness	ignorance, dullness, obstruction	inertia/downward

They are mutually opposed yet cooperative, like oil, wick and flame. Every product contains all three in different proportions.

In primordial Prakriti they undergo **sarupa-parinama**, homogeneous internal change that preserves equilibrium. Purusa's proximity disturbs balance and produces **virupa-parinama**, heterogeneous predominance initiating evolution. Rajas activates; sattva and tamas differentiate into cognitive and material lines.

Modification never creates substance from nothing. Each tattva is a new configuration of the same guna-material. This grounds both cosmology and psychology: knowledge, desire, inertia, senses and elements are stages of one material evolution.

Verdict: Guna theory unifies mind and matter without reducing one to the other, but it risks explaining diverse phenomena through highly elastic principles.

Why this earns marks: It gives nature, cooperation, two forms of modification and the cosmological-psychological payoff.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2022 Q5(a), 10 marks

Question: Examine and evaluate the proofs for Purusa.

Model solution

Samkhya gives five cumulative proofs:

1. **Sanghata-pararthatvat:** aggregates exist for another; body-mind serves a conscious subject.
2. **Trigunadi-viparyayat:** the witness must be opposite to the changing, unconscious gunas.
3. **Adhistanat:** organized experience requires a presiding consciousness.
4. **Bhoktr-bhavat:** pleasure and pain require an experiencer.
5. **Kaivalyartham pravrtteh:** striving for liberation presupposes a liberable witness.

The arguments jointly distinguish the objectifiable psychophysical apparatus from a non-objective subject. They are strongest phenomenologically: experience seems to require a standpoint not reducible to what is experienced.

Buddhists deny that aggregates exist "for" a separate owner and explain experience as a causal stream. Advaita accepts witness-consciousness but denies its plurality.

Verdict: The proofs establish a subject-pole more plausibly than they establish many eternal, wholly inactive Purusas. Their cumulative force exceeds each argument taken alone.

Why this earns marks: It lists all five technical proofs and distinguishes proof of consciousness from proof of Samkhya's full pluralist ontology.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2023 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: Present Sankara's criticism that no relation is possible between independent Purusa and Prakriti.

Model solution

Sankara argues that Samkhya's two independent principles cannot initiate a coordinated world-process. Purusa is inactive and changeless; Prakriti is unconscious. Neither can intentionally approach, affect or know the other.

If proximity is a real relation, both principles undergo relational modification and lose absolute independence. If proximity is unreal, it cannot explain the disturbance of guna-equilibrium. If it is beginningless, evolution should be continuous and liberation impossible.

The lame-and-blind analogy assumes cooperation but does not explain its ground: the lame person consciously directs the blind, whereas Purusa cannot act and Prakriti cannot understand.

Samkhya replies that proximity is not physical contact but reflective presence. A magnet moves iron without changing itself, and Prakriti operates for Purusa like milk flowing for the calf.

Verdict: The analogies clarify non-mechanical influence but do not fully explain how two independent absolutes enter a purposive relation.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs Sankara's dilemma, tests Samkhya's analogies and gives a concise evaluation.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2024 Q7(a), 20 marks

Question: Explain evolution of Prakriti and distinguish buddhi, mahat and ahamkara.

Model solution

Evolution begins when the equilibrium of sattva, rajas and tamas in avyakta Prakriti is disturbed in the presence of Purusa.

Prakriti
↓

Mahat / Buddhi



Ahamkara

- ■ sattvika line → manas + 5 cognitive senses + 5 action senses
- ■ tamasa line → 5 tanmatras → 5 gross elements
- ■ rajas → energizes both lines

Together with Prakriti and Purusa, the evolutes form twenty-five tattvas.

Mahat is the first cosmic evolute—the "great" principle of determination in the universal process. **Buddhi** is the same tattva viewed psychologically as individual determinative intellect; it performs adhyavasaya, judgement and discrimination. Thus mahat and buddhi are not two separate tattvas.

Ahamkara is the next evolute, the I-maker that appropriates experience as "I" and "mine." From its sattvika aspect arise the eleven faculties; from its tamasa aspect arise five subtle elements. Rajas supplies activity.

Buddhi is material, not consciousness. Its sattva-like transparency reflects Purusa, creating the appearance of a conscious intellect. Ahamkara misappropriates reflected consciousness and generates bondage.

Critics question how mere proximity initiates evolution and how unconscious Prakriti acts purposively. Samkhya replies that transformation is inherent in the gunas and serves the dual ends of experience and liberation.

Verdict: The scheme unifies cosmology and psychology with remarkable economy, though its first transition from independent Purusa to disturbed Prakriti remains the weakest link.

Why this earns marks: It provides the full sequence, correctly equates mahat and buddhi at two levels, distinguishes ahamkara and adds philosophical evaluation.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2025 Q7(a), 20 marks

Question: Why does Sankara call Samkhya his chief opponent, pradhana malla? Examine his arguments.

Model solution

Samkhya is Advaita's chief opponent because it offers the strongest systematic rival account of one world-ground, causation, bondage and liberation. Both seek an ultimate explanation beneath plurality and accept that ignorance causes bondage, but Samkhya proposes unconscious Pradhana and many Purusas where Advaita proposes non-dual Brahman.

Sankara's principal criticisms are:

1. **Scriptural:** Upanisadic causation passages describe an intelligent knowing source, not unconscious Pradhana.
2. **Teleological:** unconscious Prakriti cannot produce an ordered world for experience and liberation.
3. **Contact problem:** inactive Purusa and independent Prakriti cannot enter an intelligible relation.
4. **Analogy failure:** milk-calf and lame-blind examples presuppose structures absent from the two principles.
5. **Plurality problem:** qualitatively identical, attributeless Purusas lack a differentiating principle.
6. **Causal criticism:** real transformation of the ultimate threatens its independence; Advaita prefers apparent transformation.
7. **Bondage paradox:** an eternally inactive witness cannot really be bound or liberated.

Samkhya replies that material continuity requires Prakriti; the gunas explain mind and matter; plurality protects individual karma; and intelligence need not plan natural transformation. Advaita, in turn, must explain how maya and appearance arise without compromising Brahman.

Sankara treats Samkhya seriously because it cannot be dismissed as crude materialism. It shares renunciatory and discriminative aims, supplies a mature causal theory, and deeply influenced the conceptual vocabulary of Indian thought.

Verdict: Sankara's strongest objection is not mere scriptural disagreement but explanatory coordination: Samkhya cannot fully show how an unconscious independent cause evolves for an inactive independent consciousness. Yet Advaita replaces this with its own maya problem.

Why this earns marks: It explains the title pradhana malla, gives seven arguments, includes Samkhya's defence and offers a comparative final judgement.

Integrated MCQ Loop - 24 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
1	Samkhya admits: A. three pramanas B. one pramana C. four pramanas D. six pramanas	A	Perception, inference and reliable testimony.
2	The decisive inference for imperceptible Prakriti and Purusa is: A. purvavat B. samanyato-drsta C. sesavat D. kevalanvayi	B	It reaches entities not ordinarily perceived.
3	Prakriti is: A. conscious and many B. inactive witness C. one, unconscious and trigunatmaka D. created by God	C	It is the single unmanifest material root.
4	Purusa is: A. material intellect B. active creator C. guna-composite D. pure inactive consciousness	D	Purusa witnesses but does not transform.
5	The proof indicating one Prakriti is: A. avibhagat vaisvarupyasya B. adhisthanat C. bhoktr-bhavat D. asadakaranat	A	Unified diversity points to one undivided source.
6	Sattva primarily denotes: A. inertia B. illumination C. activity D. gross matter	B	Sattva manifests lightness, clarity and knowledge.
7	Rajas primarily supplies: A. obscuration B. equilibrium C. activity D. consciousness	C	It energizes both evolutionary lines.
8	Tamas primarily denotes: A. pleasure B. witnesshood C. inference D. inertia and obstruction	D	Tamas restrains and conceals.
9	Homogeneous guna-modification is: A. sarupa-parinama B. virupa-parinama C. vivarta D. arambha	A	Gunat internally change while equilibrium remains.
10	Heterogeneous transformation begins with: A. liberation B. disturbance of equilibrium C. destruction of Purusa D. divine creation	B	Unequal predominance initiates manifest evolution.
11	First evolute of Prakriti is: A. manas B. ahamkara C. mahat/buddhi D. akasa	C	Mahat is cosmic, buddhi psychological aspect.
12	Ahamkara is: A. pure consciousness B. gross element C. final liberation D. I-maker and appropriation principle	D	It turns reflected consciousness into "I" and "mine."
13	Satkaryavada holds: A. effect pre-exists in cause B. effect is wholly new C. causation is unreal D. God creates ex nihilo	A	Production is manifestation of latent effect.
14	Asadakaranat means: A. every cause is conscious B. non-being cannot be produced C. effects are illusory D. atoms are eternal	B	Absolute non-existence cannot become an effect.
15	Samkhya's causal transformation is: A. vivartavada B. arambhavada C. parinamavada D. sunyavada	C	The material cause really transforms.
16	Purusa plurality explains: A. one cosmic body B. universal simultaneous liberation C. one karmic stream D. diverse births, experiences and liberation	D	Individuality requires many witnesses.
17	Sanghata-pararthatvat argues from: A. aggregates existing for another B. scriptural testimony C. atomic combination D. absence	A	Composite instruments imply a conscious beneficiary.
18	Bhoktr-bhavat proves Purusa from: A. creation B. experience requiring an enjoyer C. universal cognition D. linguistic convention	B	Pleasure and pain require a subject.
19	Kaivalya results from: A. ritual action B. divine grace alone C. discriminative knowledge D. destruction of Prakriti	C	Viveka separates witness from material process.

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
20	Bondage is fundamentally: A. a real change in Purusa B. God's punishment C. bodily existence only D. non-discrimination and false identification	D	Purusa mistakes Prakriti's operations for its own.
21	Lame-blind analogy explains: A. cooperation of inactive consciousness and unconscious activity B. three pramanas C. Vedic authority D. atomism	A	Each supplies what the other lacks.
22	Sankara's chief criticism targets: A. guna enumeration B. relation and teleology between independent principles C. absence theory D. testimony	B	Coordination of inactive Purusa and unconscious Prakriti is obscure.
23	Jiva is: A. identical with gross body B. a fourth guna C. Purusa apparently associated with subtle body and intellect D. creator God	C	Empirical subject arises through reflection and identification.
24	Samkhya is classically: A. nihilistic B. monistic C. theistic creationism D. realist dualism and nirisvara soteriology	D	It needs no creator God for liberation or evolution.

Remedial MCQ Loop - 8 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
25	Mahat and buddhi are: A. one tattva viewed cosmically and psychologically B. separate eternal realities C. two gunas D. names of Purusa	A	Mahat is cosmic determination; buddhi its individual function.
26	The sattvika line from ahamkara produces: A. gross elements B. mind and ten faculties C. Prakriti D. Purusa	B	Manas, five cognitive and five action faculties arise.
27	The tamasa line produces: A. Purusas B. only ahamkara C. tanmatras and gross elements D. liberation	C	Subtle elements evolve into gross elements.
28	Why is Samkhya not crude materialism? A. it denies matter B. it accepts God C. it treats senses as eternal souls D. it admits irreducible pure consciousness	D	Purusa is distinct from material Prakriti.
29	Strongest defence of satkaryavada is: A. determinate causes produce determinate effects B. every effect is perceived before production C. God reveals causes D. nothing changes	A	Causal specificity supports latent capacity/effect.
30	Advaita differs by accepting: A. many independent Prakritis B. vivarta rather than real transformation of ultimate reality C. atomic creation D. Buddhist momentariness	B	World appearance does not transform Brahman.
31	The contact problem asks: A. how senses touch objects B. how gunas mix C. how inactive Purusa and independent Prakriti coordinate D. how words signify	C	Dualism lacks a clear relation mechanism.
32	Best verdict: A. Samkhya is only cosmology B. Purusa creates Prakriti C. liberation requires destroying the world D. Samkhya unifies causal realism and psychology but struggles with unconscious teleology	D	This captures strength and central weakness.

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Why is Samkhya epistemology indispensable to its metaphysics?

Model solution

Prakriti and Purusa are atindriya and cannot be perceived. Samkhya therefore restricts valid knowledge to perception, inference and testimony, then relies chiefly on samanyato-drsta inference to establish its two ultimate realities.

Manifest effects, guna-patterns and causal dependence support Prakriti; objectifiable aggregates, experience and striving for liberation support Purusa. Without this inferential bridge, the system would merely assert invisible entities.

Verdict: Samkhya metaphysics is an inferential construction constrained by its pramana theory, though critics dispute whether general correlation can prove wholly imperceptible realities.

Why this earns marks: It links epistemology directly to the proof burden for both ultimate principles.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 15 marks

Question: Does guna theory successfully unify Samkhya cosmology and psychology?

Model solution

The three gunas constitute every material and mental product. Sattva explains illumination and pleasure; rajas activity and desire; tamas inertia and obscuration. Their varying proportions explain physical, cognitive and affective diversity.

Cosmologically, guna disequilibrium generates the twenty-three evolutes. Psychologically, sattva-dominant buddhi reflects consciousness, rajas drives action and tamas obstructs discrimination. Thus mind and matter are continuous expressions of Prakriti rather than separate substances.

The theory's strength is explanatory unity. Its weakness is elasticity: almost any phenomenon can be redescribed as a guna mixture, making independent testing difficult.

Verdict: Guna theory is architecturally successful but evidentially underdetermined; it unifies the system more convincingly than it proves its three constituents.

Why this earns marks: It tests the doctrine against both domains and distinguishes explanatory integration from empirical proof.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 20 marks

Question: "Samkhya makes consciousness metaphysically pure by making agency philosophically obscure." Critically examine.

Model solution

Samkhya sharply distinguishes Purusa from every objectifiable feature. Consciousness is not body, sense, mind, ego or intellect; it is the changeless witness illuminating them. This protects subjectivity from reduction to unconscious Prakriti.

The cost is agency. Purusa cannot act, while buddhi acts but is unconscious. Empirical cognition is explained through reflection of Purusa in sattva-dominant buddhi; ahankara appropriates the result. The jiva therefore appears to know and act although its conscious pole is inactive and its active pole is non-conscious.

This division helps explain bondage as misidentification and liberation as discrimination. It also supports moral continuity through the subtle body. Yet it raises the contact problem: how can reflected consciousness arise, why does Prakriti evolve for Purusa, and who genuinely strives for liberation?

Samkhya analogies—magnet and iron, lame and blind, dancer and spectator—show asymmetric cooperation without material fusion. Critics answer that each analogy imports causal or intentional relations denied to the two principles.

Advaita solves the split by making consciousness the sole reality but inherits the problem of maya. Buddhist process theory rejects a witness but struggles with ownership. Samkhya's dualism therefore isolates a real philosophical datum even if its mechanism is incomplete.

Verdict: The statement is substantially correct. Samkhya gives one of Indian philosophy's clearest accounts of pure subjectivity, but its separation of consciousness from activity makes empirical agency and teleology its deepest unresolved problems.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates the trade-off, uses cognition and liberation mechanisms, tests analogies, compares rivals and reaches a balanced verdict.